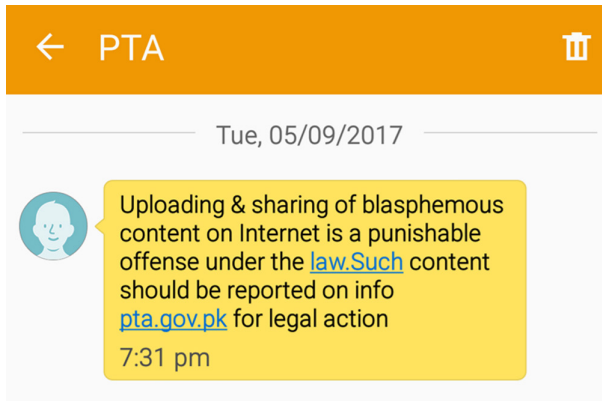


Figure 5.1 PTA SMS sent via mobile networks.

tools to examine online offences, such policies will only curtail free speech, while increasing the possible abuse of the blasphemy laws.

In its 2017 annual report PTA clearly outlines the 'nuisance of blasphemous content' (2017, p. 39), and how it 'informed the general public' about ways of reporting such content (as indicated in Figure 5.1). 'In response, PTA received, processed and blocked thousands of web links, Facebook pages etc. and the cases were also referred to the LEAs[10] for further investigation' (2017, p. 40). In using technology as a means of fighting against blasphemy, hate speech and extremism, the government under the NACTA has also launched a mobile app, available to download on Google and Apple Play stores, that 'enables citizens to report extremist content and activities anonymously and securely whenever they notice it in their areas and also on the internet. The data and information received will be shared with the Police, FIA and other law-enforcement and regulatory authorities in Pakistan' (Express Tribune 2018). In essence, citizens have become increasingly part of the state's counter-extremism agenda, instrumental not only in assisting the security state's fight against extremism, but also in upholding the national narrative (also discussed in Chapter 3).

However, PECA 2016 is useful in the manner by which it has codified laws to punish online abuse, especially sexual harassment and bullying. According to Kamal (2017), in KP 'a man was arrested for blackmailing women by uploading fake videos on social media websites' while 'a University professor was arrested for harassing a female teacher' (2017, p. 1). Yet Aziz (2018) highlights how after the initial 'hype, progress was slow' as 'citizens routinely complained of not hearing back for long periods after submitting their complaints – in cases that, to them, required urgent attention'. In situations that made it to